

Elbow Swelling - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1452 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- UAT-only adult and pediatric elbow-swelling pathway screening for septic joint or bursa, systemic illness, vascular compromise and occult trauma before in-person assessment.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How long has the swelling lasted?
2. [YES_NO] Is the skin red, hot, or painful to touch?
3. [TEMPERATURE] What is the temperature, if measured?
4. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the age; is there systemic illness, immune risk, skin wound/bite, recent infection/procedure, pregnancy/postpartum status, hidden trauma or child safeguarding concern?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Motor Vehicle Accident

Did this problem begin with a motor vehicle crash or as part of a multi-system crash injury?

A motor vehicle crash or multi-system crash injury belongs in the Motor Vehicle Accident pathway.

1. Disposition level 70

Is elbow swelling severe with neurovascular change, or is it hot/painful with marked systemic illness, confusion, breathing change, collapse or rapid deterioration?

NHS.UK joint pain guidance identifies these as reasons for urgent clinical review - a swollen, hot joint can indicate infection (septic bursitis/arthritis) needing prompt treatment; the local Qatar urgent-care pathway is used here.

1. Disposition level 70

With no emergency feature, is there any persistent or unexplained elbow swelling, redness/heat, movement restriction, child concern or higher-risk context?

In-person examination is required to distinguish septic joint/bursa, inflammatory disease, occult trauma and other causes.

Advice

Qatar emergency hot-joint response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 for an ambulance for hot swollen elbow with systemic illness, severe pain, neurovascular change or rapid deterioration; do not self-drive. Do not squeeze, drain or force movement. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: fever worsens; redness spreads.

In-person elbow-swelling assessment

- Arrange in-person assessment; telephone review cannot exclude septic arthritis/bursitis, inflammatory disease or occult trauma. Medication and exact Qatar destination are GOVERNANCE_REQUIRED.
- Call Back If: redness, warmth or fever; movement worsens.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 for an ambulance for hot swollen elbow with systemic illness, severe pain, neurovascular change or rapid deterioration; do not self-drive. Do not squeeze, drain or force movement. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Joint pain", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/joint-pain/> (page last reviewed 26 February 2026) - applied to elbow swelling

Provenance

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